

Dead in the Water — Character Sheets

Each player gets ONLY their own sheet, handed out privately at the start of Phase 1. Sebastian and Vivienne should be handed their sheets in a different room or out of view of others, since theirs contain the full plan.

The GM (Alexander) keeps the master Story Bible and Clue Deck. The GM's own sheet is included at the end as a reference.

CHARACTER SHEET — HANK WHITFIELD

Played by Daniel

Who you are. You are 56. Self-made commercial real estate. You grew up on a ranch — your father was a hard man and never gave you a dime. You worked your way to where you are, alone. You have a mild temper that flashes when pushed. You have a famous “no politics in this house” rule that you will defend at any provocation. You are the patriarch of the Whitfield family. You love your wife Catherine, your four kids and their partners, and you tolerate Richard.

Your relationship to Richard. Richard claims to be your 10th step half-brother. You have never been able to verify this. He has been writing you letters and sending you bizarre gifts (an engraved lobster fork, a nautical chart of Gig Harbor with one cove circled in red) for the past year. You agreed to host this weekend because Catherine wanted you to “for the kids.” You don’t trust Richard. You don’t want his money.

Where you were Saturday night. Bonfire from 9 PM onward. With Catherine on the patio between 11 and 12. **You did not go to the dock.**

Your secret. At 8 PM Saturday, in the gazebo, you and Richard had a private confrontation. He mocked your father, the ranch, your “self-made man” story. You shoved him into a stack of life jackets. He laughed at you. You walked out. You tore a small scrap of fabric from his green tweed jacket as you grabbed him — it’s folded inside the inner pocket of your coat, in the entryway closet. **Solomon was watching the whole thing.** You haven’t told anyone, not even Catherine, because it makes you look guilty.

What you don’t know. Anything about the actual murder.

How to play it. You are mortified. You’ll be the loudest voice trying to redirect suspicion in the early phases — that’s your tell, but the family will read it as the temper. When Solomon screeches the words you said in the gazebo (Phase 2), you’ll need to confess. Until then, deny.

Your prop. A bolo tie. Wear it.

CHARACTER SHEET — CATHERINE WHITFIELD

Played by Nicole

Who you are. You are 51. Loving, traditional, organized to a fault. You believe in keeping a clean home, an upright posture, and saying difficult things with love. You write — your first three books are on naturopathic medicine, herbal remedies, and the spiritual life. Your fourth book has been a secret.

Your relationship to Richard. You found his letters charming when they first arrived. You convinced Hank to host this weekend “for the kids.” You have been polite to Richard while quietly horrified by his theatrical cruelty. He gave you a vintage bottle of orange blossom water on Friday — beautiful, but too much.

Where you were Saturday night. You tended the bonfire from 9 PM onward, with brief trips inside. With Hank on the patio between 11 and 12.

Your secret. You have been writing a tell-all family memoir for the past three years. *Things My Mother Knew*. It contains uncomfortable truths about every Whitfield (and step-Whitfield, and former step-Whitfield). You sent a draft to a publisher in March. On Friday you discovered Richard had somehow obtained a copy — he hinted at it during dinner in front of everyone, smiling. You panicked. At 9:30 PM Saturday you slipped into Richard’s guest room, took the draft from his desk, and burned every page in the bonfire.

What you’re hiding. Nothing physical. You destroyed the evidence. But a single page survived, charred at the edges, and is in the cooled fire pit ash.

What you don’t know. Anything about the actual murder.

How to play it. Composed and loving. When the burned page is found in Phase 3, you confess. Frame it as protecting the family, not deceiving them. Hank is going to look at you very differently afterwards.

Your prop. A silk scarf around your neck and a small notebook with a pen tucked into the spine.

CHARACTER SHEET — VIVIENNE “VIVI” HAWTHORNE

Played by Sophia

PRIVATE. This sheet contains the full plan. Read it alone. Do not let anyone see it. Burn after reading. (Don't actually burn it.)

Who you are. You are 26. The Princess of the Whitfield family — only daughter, loved by everyone. You live in NYC. Your job in PR for Beiersdorf is glamorous and unfulfilling. You love theater, food, singing, and being adored. You are married to Sebastian.

Your relationship to Richard. He doted on you. You were his “Princess.” For the past year you have been writing him secretly, asking for help to leave PR for theater. He had been kind in his replies but firm. **Saturday afternoon at 3 PM, he pulled you aside.** He told you he was leaving everything to TURD — the Tortoise Urgent Rescue Division. He thought you'd be proud. You smiled. You said you were.

Where you were Saturday night. Bonfire from 11:30 PM to midnight, telling a long, performative Broadway story to the family.

YOUR SECRET — YOU AND SEBASTIAN PLANNED THE MURDER TOGETHER.

You walked back to the boathouse Saturday afternoon, found Sebastian, and told him about TURD. Within two hours you had a plan. He would do it. You would distract.

You wrote “11:35 — go” on a small note and gave it to him.

At 11:30 PM you launched into a Broadway story you had told before — you needed something long that no one would interrupt. **It was the same story you told at last Christmas dinner.** You filled time on purpose.

You did not see the murder happen. Just before 11:30, you slipped up to the primary suite balcony with a pair of opera binoculars and made sure the dock was empty — no one else approaching. You left the binoculars on the loveseat (you meant to come back for them but you never did) and came down to start your story right at 11:30.

At **11:55 PM**, after Sebastian was back, you excused yourself briefly upstairs. In the master bathroom you balled up a sticky note that said “*breathe. it's done.*” and dropped it in the trash. You came back down at 12:02 AM saying you “felt the wine going to your head” (we are a dry house — be careful with that line).

What you're hiding. *Everything.* The plan. The conversation with Richard. The opera binoculars on the balcony. The Christmas-story trick. The reason you were so calm Sunday morning.

What you must lie about. Whether Richard told you anything Saturday afternoon. Whether you saw anything from upstairs. Whether your handwriting matches the “11:35 — go” note. The Christmas story.

How to play it. Charming, devastated, deflective. Lean on grief. Lean on shock. You are the Princess — play it. When Sebastian is unmasked in Phase 4, you must perform horror. You do *not* admit anything in Phase 4.

Your break. In Phase 5, when the Christmas-story detail surfaces and either Hank or Catherine recognizes the Broadway story, you have ten seconds. The GM (Alexander) will guide you to the truth. Your final confession is heavy. You are not asking for forgiveness; you are explaining.

Your prop. Oversized black sunglasses (worn indoors as a Princess bit) and a single theater playbill you carry.

CHARACTER SHEET — SEBASTIAN HAWTHORNE

Played by Jaymon

PRIVATE. This sheet identifies you as the killer. Read it alone. Do not let anyone see it.

Who you are. You are 30. Smart, calculating, sarcastic, hard to read. You are MBA-bound — you’ve taken on six figures in loans for an Ivy program starting in the fall. You want to be on Wall Street. You enjoy strategy games and the taste of certainty. Your sense of humor is loving mockery and sarcasm. You don’t always like to admit when you’re having a good time.

Your relationship to Richard. Outwardly cordial. Privately, you saw him as your route into real money. You and Vivi had been quietly drowning in NYC for over a year — apartment lease, MBA debt, deposits on a private placement you’d “got into” through a friend — all of it sized to an inheritance you hadn’t seen yet but assumed was coming.

Where you were Saturday night. “Stepped outside for some air” 11:30 PM to 11:50 PM. A twenty-minute “smoke break.”

YOUR SECRET — *YOU KILLED HIM.*

Saturday afternoon Vivi found you in the boathouse with the news that Richard was leaving everything to TURD. You and Vivi planned together over two hours. You would go to the dock at 11:35. She would distract the bonfire group with a long Broadway story.

You took the loose dock cleat that had been wobbly all weekend (Vivi had noticed it). You swung once. Richard fell, struck the piling, went into the shallows. You threw the cleat into the lake. You took the notarized envelope from his portfolio. You walked back to the bonfire at 11:50.

What you’re hiding.

- The notarized envelope is folded in the inside pocket of your navy blazer, which is hanging on the back of your breakfast chair. (*You did not have a chance to move it before the body was found.*)
- The “11:35 — go” note from Vivi is folded behind it.
- Your handwritten ledger of inheritance vs. debt is in a Monopoly box on the bottom floor — you put it there because nobody plays Monopoly.
- The diagram of the dock layout you drew Friday night is taped behind the orca mural on the bottom floor. You forgot it was there.

What you must lie about. The smoke break (you said you needed air). The envelope (you don’t know where it is). The diagram (you’ve never seen it). The ledger (it’s just expense tracking, completely normal).

How to play it. Cool, dry, slightly above the conversation. Click your pen when nervous

— it's an honest tell, leave it in. You will be smug in Phase 2 (you think you're clever). You will be uneasy in Phase 3 (the diagram and the ledger surface). You will break in Phase 4.

Your break. When Cody pulls out his phone and shows the "\$60M → TURD" photo, the room has motive, means, and opportunity. You can deny once. You cannot deny twice. Your confession is short and clean.

Important — protect Vivi in Phase 4. When you confess, do *not* implicate her. You take the fall alone. You think you are protecting her. You are not. The Christmas-story detail in Phase 5 will come for her regardless.

Your prop. A clip-on tie and a navy blazer (any sport coat with an inside pocket — the GM will plant the envelope there before guests arrive).

CHARACTER SHEET — ISABELLE “BELLA” REYES

Played by Samantha

Who you are. You are 25. You work for a humanitarian non-profit (International Schools Initiative) that builds schools and teaches English in under-developed nations. You're sweet, you're tough, you fight for yourself. You're engaged to Alexander — but you're a guest at this lake house, not a Whitfield, and you're still working on feeling like one of them.

Your relationship to Richard. Richard met you at a Whitfield Christmas dinner two years ago. He'd told you, at length, how moved he was by your work. He promised your non-profit a \$250,000 donation toward a Cambodia school. He invited you up this weekend “to lock in the details.”

Where you were Saturday night. Helping in the kitchen prepping s'mores and mocktails 9–10:30. Bonfire 10:30 onward.

Your secret. Saturday afternoon you discovered Richard had been stringing you along. The donation was never coming. You confronted him alone in the gazebo at 7 PM. He laughed at you. You walked out fuming. You have spent Sunday morning drafting the apology email to your boss in your head.

What you're hiding. Nothing physical — just the fight. You're terrified the gazebo confrontation makes you look like the murderer.

What you don't know. Anything about the actual murder.

How to play it. Tense, defensive, sharper than usual. When the torn guestbook page surfaces in Phase 3, you confess. Frame it as a fight, not a threat. The room will sympathize.

Your prop. A lanyard with an “International Schools Initiative” badge and a clipboard with a few non-profit-looking forms. (The GM will print the badge for you.)

CHARACTER SHEET — BEAU WHITFIELD

Played by Colin

Who you are. You are 22. The middle child. Fiery red hair. You are currently obsessed with the gym (the obsession changes every few months). Last year was spoon rings. The year before that was your never-quite-launched merch line “Beau Thats Hot.” You’re working full-time and trying to decide whether to go to school. You only do something if you actually want to do it. You are loud, funny, and never a dull moment.

Your relationship to Richard. Friday night, after dinner, you pitched Richard on becoming an investor in a “Beau Thats Hot” relaunch. He laughed in your face. He said your idea had “the marketing instincts of a teen with a TikTok addiction.” You smiled and said “respect the honesty.”

Where you were Saturday night. Bonfire and patio. You were tossing a football with Cody and Levi 9-10. You walked off briefly at 10 PM to “use the bathroom.”

Your secret. At 10 PM, instead of the bathroom, you snuck to where Richard had stashed his case of glass-bottle root beer in the kitchen and stole the entire case. You hid it under the second blue kayak on the patio. You drank one bottle. You wanted Richard to walk into the bonfire later, ask for a root beer, and find an empty space where his case had been. You wanted to watch his face.

What you’re hiding. The location of the case. (Under the second kayak.) **Solomon witnessed the theft** and now screeches “*WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!*” every time the energy in the room dips.

What you don’t know. Anything about the actual murder.

How to play it. Performatively unbothered. Crack jokes. Crack more jokes. When the empty bottle is found in Phase 3, you can deny it. When the case is found, you confess. The room will laugh. You are not in real trouble.

Your prop. A gym sweatband headband and a frosted plastic shaker bottle.

CHARACTER SHEET — EDEN HARTLEY

Played by Emma

Who you are. You are 22. Beau's longtime girlfriend. You teach dance to children. You are the sweetest person any of these people have ever met, and they tell you so often. Your mother passed away three years ago. Your father is essentially estranged. Your grandparents are your greatest source of love. The Whitfields have adopted you as one of their own, and you love them back.

Your relationship to Richard. Most of the family resented Richard. You felt sorry for him. He was, you suspected, a lonely person playing a theatrical character. Friday afternoon, before dinner, he gave you a small leather-bound book of his late mother's poems and told you, quietly, that you reminded him of her.

Friday night, after dinner, he pulled you aside privately and told you something else. He said he was including your grandparents in his will — \$50,000 each, to "make their final years easier." You hadn't asked. You hadn't known he even knew their names. He asked you to keep it secret until the midnight reveal. You were moved to tears. You did not tell anyone, not even Beau. *Especially* not Beau.

Where you were Saturday night. Playing board games on the bottom floor 8-10. Bonfire 10 onward.

Your secret. Saturday afternoon you started to wonder. Richard had been so cruel to Beau and so theatrical with the rest of the family — why would he be privately, quietly kind to grandparents he'd never mentioned, in a real way involving real money? You started to suspect he was lying to you. Testing you. Toying with you the way he toyed with everyone.

At 9 PM you went to his guest room to verify. You opened his leather portfolio. There was no mention of your grandparents anywhere. There was a single sheet that said "**\$60M → TURD (final)**" in his handwriting. The entire estate was going to a charity called TURD.

Richard had lied to you. He had used your grandparents — your single greatest source of love — to manipulate you, and you had no idea why. You felt humiliated.

You took the leather-bound book of poems he'd offered you Friday (the one real thing he'd actually given you). You left a handwritten thank-you note on his desk as cover for being there. You rearranged a small framed photo absently, the way you do when you're trying to hold yourself together. You walked out.

You told no one. You couldn't tell Beau — he would be furious that you'd hidden Richard's kindness from him *and* furious that you'd been played. You couldn't tell anyone in the Whitfield family — they would wonder why you hadn't said something. So you carried it alone.

What you're hiding. - The book of poems is in your overnight bag. - The thank-you note

is on Richard's desk (a Phase 3 clue). - **You have known the truth about TURD since 9 PM Saturday.** You have not told anyone.

What you don't know. Anything about the actual murder.

How to play it. Sweet, loyal, quietly hurt — but holding it in. You're the family's emotional center; you can't fall apart, but something is wrong with you all morning and Beau will sense it.

*In Phase 3, when the thank-you note is found, **confess only the surface.*** Admit you went to his room to thank him for the book. Do *not* reveal that you saw the TURD paper. Frame the visit as innocent. The room will sympathize and move on.

In Phase 4, after Cody pulls out his phone and shows the "\$60M → TURD" photo, you have your real moment. Step forward. Quietly: "I saw it too. At nine, in his room. I'm sorry. He told me Friday he was leaving something to my grandparents. I went to verify. He had lied to me. I couldn't bring myself to admit he'd done that to me." The room turns. Another person knew. Cody's photo gets corroborated. Beau's face will be something to watch.

Your prop. A small flower hair clip or a satin dance ribbon tied around your wrist.

CHARACTER SHEET — LEVI WHITFIELD

Played by Luke

Who you are. You are 18. Just graduated. Headed to BYU in the fall. Bleached blonde hair, thrifted clothes, AirPods in one ear. You play golf and you are very good at it. You like to act uninterested. You are, secretly, a hard worker. You also somehow have rich friends with three-tier houseboats. You manipulate them into doing things for you. You learned this from your older brothers, who manipulated you, who learned it from theirs.

Your relationship to Richard. Tepid. You found him weird. You were mostly on your phone the whole weekend.

Where you were Saturday night (the official version). On the porch with Alexander 10 PM to 12:30 AM. You and he were “looking at the stars.” Alexander has agreed to confirm this when asked.

Your secret. You weren’t on the porch. You were on Wyatt’s family’s three-tier houseboat playing late-night cards (chips, not money — *please remember this distinction. It is important. Not money.*) with five rich friends from Mercer Island. You snuck out at 10 and snuck back at 12:30. Alexander didn’t ask why; you said you needed to “be off the property for a bit.” He covered for you.

What you’re hiding. The boarding ticket from Lake Saunders Houseboat Marina is under your mattress. Your phone has time-stamped photos of you at the houseboat at 11:35 PM, when the murder was happening.

What you don’t know. Anything about the actual murder. (You weren’t even there.)

How to play it. Performatively bored. AirPods in. When the boarding ticket is found in Phase 3, you confess. **Make sure to keep clarifying that you were playing for chips, not money. Three times. Four times. Use it as a comedic beat.** While confessing, you’ll realize that admitting you weren’t at the property looks bad — you’ll need to show the photos to prove you were physically elsewhere during the murder.

Your prop. A cheap bucket hat and a single golf glove. AirPods optional.

CHARACTER SHEET — CODY WHITFIELD

Played by Ben

Who you are. You are 14. The youngest. Red hair. You play tackle football and love it. You like to act unbothered, like teenagers do. You sometimes feel like the family forgets you because everyone else is older and out of the house. You don't admit this. You will, however, fully act like a teenager about it, which involves saying "whatever" a lot.

Your relationship to Richard. You thought Richard was funny. He talked to you at dinner like you were an adult, which you appreciated. He told you on Friday that you reminded him of himself at your age, which you weren't sure how to feel about.

Where you were Saturday night. Bonfire and patio. In bed by 11:30. You missed the murder.

Your secret. Saturday afternoon, around 2:15 PM, you snuck into Richard's guest room out of pure curiosity. You wanted to see what was in his big leather portfolio. You opened it. There was a paper inside that said, in his handwriting: "\$60M → TURD (final)." You did not know what TURD was. You took a photo on your phone. You closed the portfolio. You left. You didn't tell anyone.

What you're hiding. The photo on your phone. (The GM will help you set this up — they'll print a paper that says exactly that, photograph it on your phone before the game starts, so the photo is real.)

What you don't know. What TURD is, or that the photo is the most important clue in the entire investigation.

Your big moment.

This is your character sheet, so you should know: you are the hero of this game. Not loud-hero. Quiet-hero. You hold the secret all morning. You sit on your phone. You don't volunteer anything.

In Phase 4, Alexander will turn to you and say: "Cody. Anything you've been holding onto?"

That's your cue. Pull out the phone. Show the photo. Hand it to whoever is closest. The room will absolutely lose its mind. Sebastian will be unmasked because of you.

You don't need to act. You just need to be patient. Be quiet. Be a teenager. When Alexander looks at you, you deliver. Trust the process.

Your prop. A small football to toss and a backwards baseball cap. Keep your phone on you the whole game.

GM SHEET — ALEXANDER (the house manager)

Played by Alex

Who you are. You are the Whitfields' lake house resident manager. They hired you four years ago to maintain the property year-round. You know this house the way they know each other — by feel. You have keys to every room. You know everyone's habits. You took the photos. You kept the schedule. Saturday morning you were up before anyone, prepping breakfast, when you walked out for firewood and saw Richard's body in the shallows.

Your role in the game. You are the omniscient narrator. You hold every clue. You walk the family from phase to phase. You play Solomon's voice. You read the auto-reveals. You enforce the soft-locks. You guide Cody to the hero turn.

You are not a suspect. You have no secret. The family trusts you. You speak with quiet authority.

Your only line of fiction. In Phase 3, when Levi confesses to sneaking out, you confirm: *"He asked me to cover for him. I did. I didn't know where he was actually going. I'm sorry."*

Your prop. A clipboard with the printed weekend schedule, a ring of keys, and a "ALEXANDER · HOUSE MANAGER" name tag pinned to your shirt. Full Clue-butler energy.

Tools you hold. The GM Story Bible, the Clue Deck, and the GM Guide (forthcoming). Solomon the parrot (a stuffed bird with a backstory — you can use a real plushie or a printed silhouette propped on a perch).

Distribution notes for the GM

- Print each sheet on its own page (they're already separated by ---).
- Hand sheets out privately at the start of Phase 1. Vivienne and Sebastian should receive theirs in a different room or out of view of others — their sheets contain the full plan.
- Read aloud to each player: *"This is your sheet only. Do not show it to anyone. You may lie about anything on this sheet. You may keep secrets about anything on this sheet. The truth comes out only when the game makes it come out."*
- Cody's sheet is the most spoiler-heavy for a 14-year-old in terms of stakes — make sure he knows he's the hero so he doesn't accidentally give the photo away early. He should treat it like Christmas morning he's not allowed to open until Phase 4.